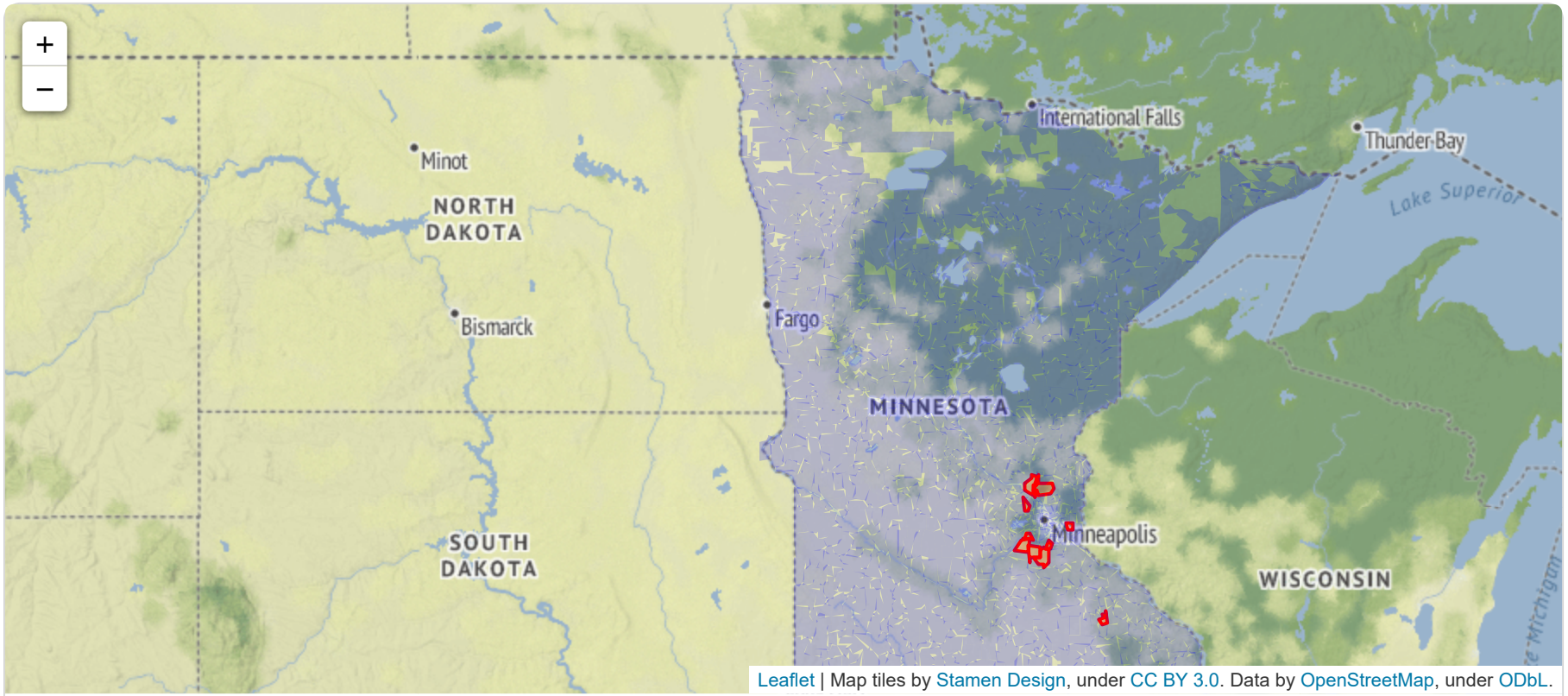


Local Account Intelligence

COLLEGES, UNIVERSITIES, AND PROFESSIONAL SCHOOLS

in the state of Minnesota

Know the Market



Top zip codes for consumer spending on college tuition

[Source: 2025 EASI Demographics]

Colleges, Universities, and Professional Schools

Includes category intelligence for professional schools and colleges, dental schools, paralegal schools, communications schools, art schools, medical schools, business administration schools, historically black colleges and universities (HBCUs), and distance education programs; college bookstores.

Industry Background

Primary NAICS Code: *611310*
Colleges, Universities, and Professional Schools

Primary SIC Code: *8221*
Colleges, Universities, and Professional Schools

Industry Intel

Colleges offer degree programs usually concentrated in a specific area such as liberal arts. A university is comprised of multiple colleges and students select a college to attend within the university framework. These institutions may also have professional schools which offer graduate degree programs leading to medical, dental, legal, and business careers. Colleges and universities can be public institutions which receive significant state funding as part of their operations.

Demand for degrees is tied to labor market returns for credentialed workers, federal financial aid policy, demographic trends in high school graduates, and employer expectations for credentials and skills. The industry also plays a wider social role through research, community engagement, and workforce development partnerships with employers and government agencies.

The category can be divided into several subsegments based on funding model, mission, and program focus.

- Public colleges and universities are state funded institutions that offer associate, bachelor, and graduate degrees at relatively lower tuition levels for in-state students. They include large research universities, regional comprehensive universities, and some specialized campuses.
- Private nonprofit colleges include liberal arts colleges, comprehensive universities, and faith based institutions that are independently governed and rely on tuition, endowments, and donations.
- Private for profit degree granting institutions focus on career-oriented programs and operate on a business model where tuition and fees must cover operating margins for investors.
- Private or independent colleges or universities rely less on government funding although some may obtain large research grants. These private institutions may often be associated with a religious group.

Traditionally, colleges and universities target the young adult population. However, they also extend programs to adult learners through continuing education and online programs.

There are approximately 3,900 degree-granting institutions across the country. Combined annual revenue totals approximately $760 billion. Approximately 35% are public institutions and about 35% are private. From 2024 to fall 2025, total U.S. postsecondary enrollment rose about 1%, to 19.4 million students, with 16.2 million undergraduates and 3.2 million graduate students; growth was driven by undergraduate gains of 1.2%, while graduate enrollment was essentially flat at -0.3%.

[Sources: AACU.org. American Association of Colleges and Universities, n.d. Web. 22 May 2026; "Educational Services: NAICS 61." bls.gov, 2025. Web. 19 May. 2026; "Higher education industry." ebsco.com, 2025. Web. 19 May. 2026; "Market Overview: Colleges, Universities, and Professional Schools (NAICS 611310)." grata.com, 2025. Web. 19 May. 2026; "Colleges and Universities in the US Industry Analysis." ibisworld.com, 2025. Web. 19 May. 2026; "Embedding Industry and Professional Certifications within Higher Education." luminafoundation.org, 2025 (report republished in updated collection). Web. 19 May. 2026; "Fast Facts: Educational institutions (1122)." NCES.ed.gov, n.d. Web. 19 May. 2026.]

Items commonly offered by Colleges, Universities, and Professional Schools

- Day & evening classes
- Regional campuses
- Placement services
- Small classes
- Accredited
- Tutoring
- Financial assistance
- Online classes
- Picturesque campus
- Semester & short classes
- Professional career training

Related Industries

Historically Black Colleges and Universities (HBCUs) are institutions that were established prior to 1964 and have the principal mission of educating Black Americans.

According to the latest government data, there are currently 101 HBCUs located in 19 states, the District of Columbia, and the U.S. Virgin Islands.

The number of students enrolled in HBCUs witnessed a significant surge of 47% between 1976 and 2010, going from 223,000 to 327,000 students. However, this figure experienced an 11% decline to 289,000 students between 2010 and 2022. Nonetheless, the number of HBCU students in 2022 remained consistent with the pre-coronavirus pandemic levels of 2019, also rounded to 289,000 students.

In comparison, the overall student population in all degree-granting institutions exhibited a growth of 91% from 11.0 million to 21.0 million students between 1976 and 2010, followed by a decline of 12% to 18.6 million students between 2010 and 2022.

The total revenue for HBCUs in 2019–20 was $9.0 billion, with $1.9 billion from student tuition and fees. [Source: “Historically Black Colleges and Universities.” National Center for Education Statistics. Nces.ed.gov.]

COLLEGE BOOKSTORES

This industry is broken down as follows:

- Institutionally owned campus bookstores: These stores are owned and operated directly by colleges or universities. They function as auxiliary enterprises whose goal is to support the institution’s academic mission while at least breaking even financially. Institutional stores work closely with academic departments, faculty, library staff, and administrators to manage course adoptions and to lower costs for students. They typically also sell branded apparel, technology, and convenience items, and often serve as visible “front doors” for campus visitors. Leased or outsourced bookstores (corporate operated): Under this model, the store space is on or near campus but operated by an external bookstore management company under a lease or management contract with the institution. The two dominant operators are Barnes and Noble Education and Follett Higher Education, which together run more than half of U.S. campus stores.
- Cooperative or nonprofit bookstores: Cooperative stores are typically owned by students and faculty, often structured as nonprofits with a board of trustees or directors. Profits are usually reinvested into lower prices, scholarships, or student services. Co-ops emphasize democratic governance and may prioritize affordability and academic freedom in course material selection, while still needing to manage textbook logistics and retail operations similar to other campus stores.
- Independent institutionally affiliated bookstores: A shrinking but important segment consists of independent campus stores, often long-standing operations historically run by universities or local organizations. Recent reporting indicates that out of several thousand U.S. campus bookstores, only about

300 remain independent. These stores tend to have high levels of integration with institutional culture, often curate local authors and faculty titles, and may provide more customized services but face capital and technology constraints versus large chains.

- Hybrid and split-model operations: Some campuses separate core textbook distribution from other retail functions. For example, a corporate partner may handle course materials, while a university-run “spirit shop” manages branded apparel and gift items in a distinct space. Other schools maintain a primary bookstore plus satellite locations on multiple campuses or pop-up retail for events. These hybrid models are designed to maximize profitability from high-margin merchandise while controlling or outsourcing lower-margin textbook operations.
- Digital and virtual campus bookstores: A growing subcategory is digital-first or virtual bookstores that distribute course materials primarily online, often embedded directly in the learning management system. These operations may have limited or no physical footprint for textbooks, focusing instead on digital delivery, inclusive access billing, and logistics for print-on-demand or shipped materials.

The most recent data from NACS reported that there are approximately 4,000 bookstores providing service to U.S. higher education institutions.

Beyond retail, campus bookstores are seen as hubs for campus culture. Leaders describe their stores as central academic and community spaces that reinforce campus identity through branded merchandise and provide everyday essentials, technology, and resources in one place. Events such as faculty book signings, student organization pop-ups, and orientation activities keep the store tied into campus life even as the mix of goods evolves.
[Sources: ICBAinc.com, n.d. Web. 19 May 2026; NACS.org, n.d. Web. 19 May 2026; Follett.com, n.d. Web. 19 May 2026.]

Executive Summary

6.5% of US adults said "College tuition for you or a family member (not student loan debt)" when asked "When it comes to personal, financial or professional services or investments, I expect to pay for the following in the next 12 months..."

Top sales months for Colleges, Universities, and Professional Schools are: January, August, September.

The Annual Advertising/Marketing Budget is approximately **0.69%** of retail sales -
Higher education marketing budgets typically range from about $200,000 to $3 million.
Specifically, in 2024, the latest year for which full-year data is available, total spending by media type was as follows:

- Digital spend: $904M (+7.8%)
- Television: $354M (+8.8%)
- Radio: $42M (-2.3%)
- Newspaper: $17M (+41.7%)
- Magazines: $16M (-31.3%)

Higher education institutions are increasingly shifting ad dollars toward localized marketing strategies. In 2024, local advertising spend grew from 9% to 19% of total media budgets year over year, while national spend declined from 91% to 81%.
The shift toward local advertising reflects changing student media consumption habits and a broader industry focus on more targeted, personalized recruitment campaigns.
Online only educational institutions spend $1.2M or 11.9% of revenue.

Larger physical schools have a $4.15M marketing budget. 50% of the budget is spent on staffing.

Of the remainder, the spending breaks out as:

- Enrollment 72%
- Branding 24%
- Advancement 6%

There is at least one co-op advertising plan available: Penguin Random House- Distributors

30.9% of U.S. adults believe that colleges/universities (including trade schools) are credible in what they say and do, and have their best interest at heart.

You can confidently lead with social network advertising as a conversion driver, not just an awareness tactic. **80% of College Tuition Buyers** took action after seeing an ad on a social network in the past year.

College Tuition Buyers are **206% more likely** to read a blog every day.

Source: Exclusive research from AdMall, SalesFuel and our reliable partners - not available from AI.

Know the Opportunities

Limited-Time Opportunities+Shareables

Upcoming National Event Tie-Ins

- National Novel Writing Month
- National Drunk and Drugged Driving Prevention Month
- National Condom Month
- Library Lovers' Month
- Pi Day
- National STD Education & Awareness Month
- National Poetry Month
- National Sexual Assault Awareness & Prevention Month
- Audio Book Appreciation Month
- National Hispanic Heritage Month
- National Bullying Prevention Month

Opportunities+Challenges

Nontraditional learners are an expanding opportunity segment, with institutions increasingly dependent on flexible, inclusive recruitment strategies as the “New Majority” grows, and nearly 10% of first-year students are non-native English speakers, signaling a shift beyond traditional high school pipelines.

Source: "Higher Ed Trends to Watch in 2026." herzing.edu, 20 Jan. 2026. Web. 22 May 2026.

The 2026–2027 enrollment cliff presents a structural decline in traditional-age college students that will intensify competition for 18–24-year-olds and force institutions to expand marketing and recruitment toward adult learners, transfer students, and flexible upskilling programs.

Source: "Mitigating the Impact of the 2026–2027 Enrollment Cliff." carnegiehighered.com, 2024. Web. 2026.

Online and hybrid learning have become baseline expectations, creating an opportunity for colleges to position flexible, fully online and hybrid programs as a core enrollment driver, especially for working adults and caregivers seeking accessible, career-focused education.

Source: "What's Driving US Higher Education Enrollment Trends in 2026." cengagegroup.com, 2026. Web. 2026.

Erosion of the traditional revenue model is increasing financial pressure on colleges as enrollment stagnates, tuition constraints tighten, and ROI scrutiny grows, forcing marketing to shift toward clear value, cost transparency and outcomes tied to careers, earnings, and time-to-degree.

Source: "2026 Higher Education Trends." deloitte.com, 2026. Web. 2026.

Dual enrollment and early college pathways are a key growth opportunity, expanding the student pipeline by engaging high schoolers early and positioning colleges to increase enrollment while reducing time-to-degree and cost through strong partnerships with schools and families.

Source: "What's Driving US Higher Education Enrollment Trends in 2026." cengagegroup.com, 2026. Web. 2026.



Colleges are evolving their revenue models by diversifying beyond traditional undergraduate tuition—expanding continuing education, professional programs, online divisions, and nontraditional student segments to stabilize enrollment and strengthen financial sustainability.

Source: "Colleges and Universities in the US Industry Analysis." ibisworld.com, 2025. Web. 19 May. 2026.



International enrollment volatility, driven by visa uncertainty and reported declines in both new and graduate international students, creates revenue risk for institutions that rely heavily on full-pay international populations, requiring diversified recruitment strategies across resilient global markets and stronger domestic graduate and STEM pipelines.

Source: "2026 Higher Education Trends." deloitte.com, 2026. Web. 2026.



Colleges have a major opportunity at the top of the enrollment funnel, as prospective students most often start their research via Google (42%) or directly on school websites (38%), making search presence and website experience critical first touchpoints in shaping interest and applications.

Source: "Marketing and Enrollment Management Benchmarks 2025." educationdynamics.com, 2025. Web. 22 May 2026.



Higher education marketing is increasingly shifting toward bold, differentiated storytelling that prioritizes institutional culture, student experience, and clear ROI outcomes over rankings, while using highly targeted digital channels and tighter budget discipline to prove enrollment impact.

Source: "How higher education marketers can win students with new creative approaches and media strategies." adage.com, 7 Apr. 2026. Web. 22 May 2026.



Public skepticism about higher education ROI is rising even amid enrollment recovery, forcing colleges to directly address concerns about cost, debt, and job outcomes by emphasizing transparent metrics like earnings, placement rates, and net price to reframe degrees as practical investments.

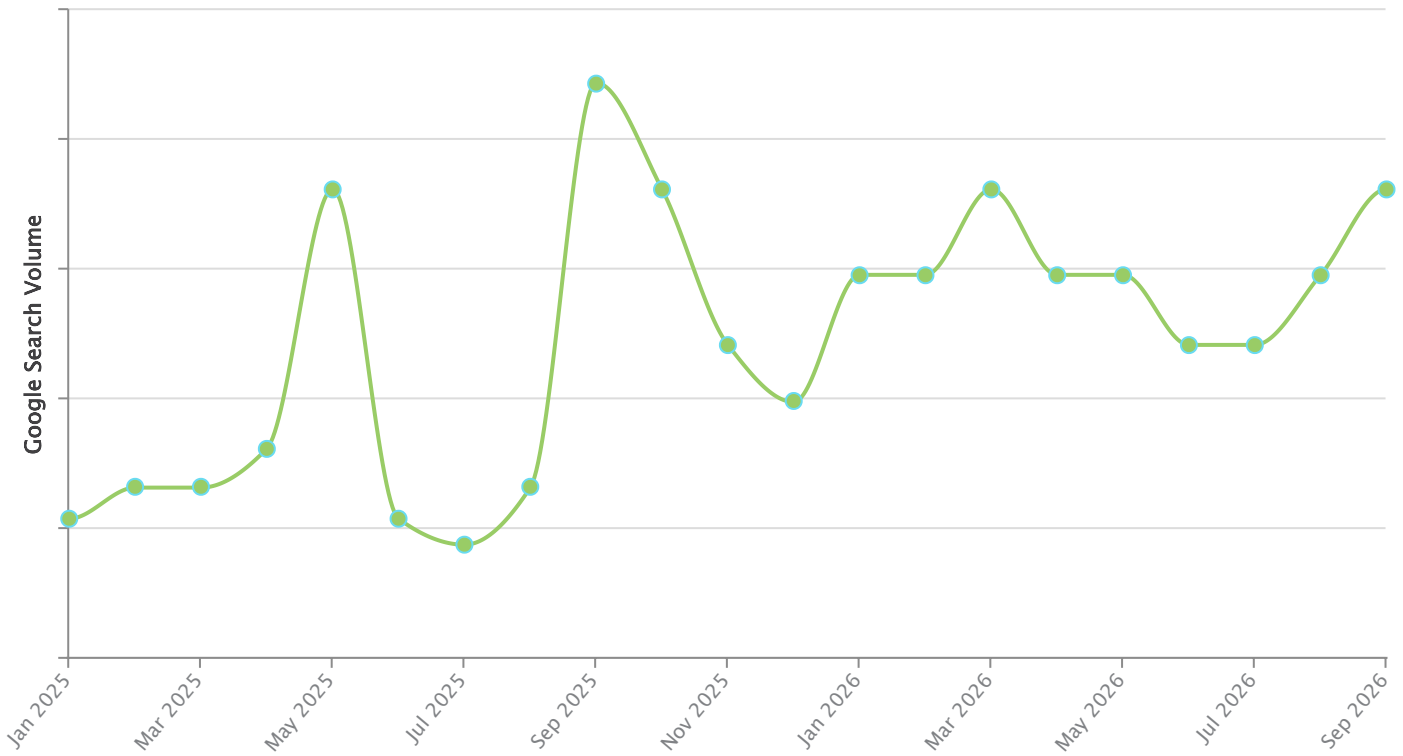
Source: "2026 Higher Education Trends." deloitte.com, 2026. Web. 2026.

Discovery Questions

- Thinking about your last major marketing or enrollment investment, what did not work the way you expected, and what did you learn from that outcome that should shape any new initiative we discuss?
- Where do you see the biggest disconnect between the story your institution tells publicly (brand, value, outcomes) and what your current students actually experience day to day, and how is that gap showing up in your data?
- When you look at your enrollment mix over the next five years, which specific student segment worries you the most from a revenue standpoint, and what have you already tried to stabilize or grow that segment?

Know the Category

Peak Interest Months



Graph displays the trend line of search volume for this industry over the last 12 months. Source: DataforSEO November 02, 2026

Peak Sales Months/Seasons

- [x] January
- [ ] February
- [ ] March
- [ ] April
- [ ] May
- [ ] June
- [ ] July
- [x] August
- [x] September
- [ ] October
- [ ] November
- [ ] December

Generally, schools' highest enrollment and revenues typically occur in the fall, which corresponds to the second and third quarters of schools' traditional fiscal year. Enrollment is slightly lower in the spring, and the lowest enrollment generally occurs during the summer months. Vocational/technical schools may have more frequent enrollment times.
[Sources: "Average Cost of College: Yearly Tuition and Expenses." educationdata.org, 2026. Web. 19 May. 2026; "Current Term Enrollment Estimates." NSCresearchcenter.org, 2025. Web. 19 May. 2026.]

Purchase Consideration Cycle

Academic calendars have an influence on this industry's buying cycle. Depending on whether the school follows semesters or quarters, potential students may be touring or visiting during set periods. Typically, early application deadlines are in November, with admissions decisions that come out in December. The regular application deadline is normally around the first of January. These students expect to hear back around mid-to-late March or early April.
[Source: "When Does College Start? Dates for Fall and Spring." Coursera.org, 29 Nov. 2023. Web. Feb. 2024.]

Top Product Categories

- Degree programs (associate, bachelor, graduate, and professional degrees)
- Room and board (student housing and dining plans)
- Continuing education, certificates, and nondegree programs
- Online and distance education programs (fully online degrees and hybrid offerings)
- Research and sponsored programs
- Clinical services (for medical, dental, and health professional schools)
- Auxiliary services (housing-adjacent, dining-adjacent, and campus services)
- Campus retail and course materials (bookstores and branded merchandise)
- Events, athletics, and facility rentals

[Sources: “College Scorecard.” ed.gov, 2026. Web. 19 May. 2026; "The Financial State of Higher Education and What It Means for Business Officers.” nacubo.org, 2025. Web. 19 May. 2026.]

Annual Advertising/Marketing Budget

approximately **0.69%** of retail sales -

[Source: Weiner, George. "University & Higher Education Fundraising Study." wholewhale.com. 2024. Web. 17 Jun. 2025.]

Higher education marketing budgets typically range from about $200,000 to $3 million.
[Source: "Agencies are deepening their expertise in higher education—here are the opportunities and challenges." adage.com, 8 Apr. 2026. Web. 22 May 2026.]

Specifically, in 2024, the latest year for which full-year data is available, total spending by media type was as follows:

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The shift toward local advertising reflects changing student media consumption habits and a broader industry focus on more targeted, personalized recruitment campaigns.
[Source: "Marketing and Enrollment Management Benchmarks 2025." educationdynamics.com, 2025. Web. 22 May 2026.]

Online only educational institutions spend $1.2M or 11.9% of revenue.

Larger physical schools have a $4.15M marketing budget. 50% of the budget is spent on staffing.

Of the remainder, the spending breaks out as:

- Enrollment 72%
- Branding 24%
- Advancement 6%

[Sources: Key Findings from UPCEA Marketing Survey. Upcea.edu. 2025. Web. 8 Sep. 2026; Arena, Tess. “Marketing teams are stretched thin. Eab.com. 1 Sep. 2026. Web. 8 Sep. 2026]

Top Advertising Media Used

NON-DIGITAL

- High school outreach and counselor relationships
- Print materials mailed to homes
- Print advertising
- Direct outreach by admissions and recruitment staff
- Events at community and employer sites
- Alumni and word-of-mouth referral programs
- Outdoor branding on and around campus
- Print collateral at partner locations

DIGITAL

- Search engine optimization (SEO) for program and degree pages
- Paid search and display advertising (PPC)
- Social media marketing
- Email marketing and marketing automation
- Content marketing
- Retargeting and geotargeted display ads
- Video marketing and virtual tours
- Chatbots and live chat on college websites
- Reputation management and online reviews

[Sources: “Marketing and Recruitment Practices Benchmarking Report.” EAB.com, 2024. Web. 19 May. 2026; “Reaching Today’s Students: Marketing and Recruitment Practices for Higher Education.” UPCEA.edu, 2025. Web. 19 May. 2026.]

Organic search continues to be a major driver of higher education website performance and engagement. Year over year, organic traffic increased by 12%, while website conversions rose by 15%, highlighting the growing effectiveness of SEO and content-driven strategies. Page views increased year-over-year by 23%, with visitors averaging 2.27 page views per session, suggesting that institutions are improving website experiences, content relevance and visitor retention.

An industry study found that website traffic comes from:

- Organic Search: 35%
- Direct: 27%
- Paid Search: 14%
- Referral: 9%
- Paid Social: 4%
- Email: 3%
- Paid Other: 2%
- Organic Social: 2%
- Unassigned: 2%
- Display: 1%
- Cross-network: 1%
- Paid Video: 1%
- Organic Video: 0.2%
- Organic Shopping: 0.1%
- SMS: 0.03%
- Audio: 0.01%

[Source: "Marketing and Enrollment Management Benchmarks 2025." educationdynamics.com, 2025. Web. 22 May 2026.]

CONSUMER MEDIA USE

Prospective students typically begin their college research process:

- Google search - 42%
- School website - 38%
- Call/Email school - 9%
- Social media follow - 4%
- Other - 6%

Additionally, 51% of students reported using AI as part of their college research process though 48% say they only somewhat trust AI when evaluating schools. 28% say they totally trust AI for school evaluation.

When looking at a college's website, prospective students say they want to see:

- Available programs - 73%
- Cost of tuition - 72%
- Cost of fees - 63%
- Course listings - 56%
- Program curriculum - 51%
- Program start dates - 43%
- Scholarship information - 42%
- Format (online, hybrid, in-person) - 40%
- Accreditation - 33%

[Source: "Marketing and Enrollment Management Benchmarks 2025." educationdynamics.com, 2025. Web. 22 May 2026.]

87% of traditional undergraduates use Instagram, 82% of graduate students use Facebook, and 41% of graduate students use LinkedIn. Overall, 44% of these social media users say they follow schools. All users are more likely to say they watch ads on Facebook than other social networks.

Graduate students were the most receptive to social media advertising, reporting the highest rates of ads being “very helpful” across LinkedIn (50%), Facebook (46%), Instagram (42%), X (38%), and TikTok (35%). Their stronger information-seeking behaviors and focus on career outcomes likely increase engagement with ads featuring program details, institutional value, and career advancement opportunities.

Note also that traditional undergraduates remain more influenced by experiential and campus-based engagement, with 15% applying at a college fair or similar event, compared to just 5% of non-traditional undergraduates.
[Source: "Modern Learner 2.0." educationdynamics, 2026. Web. 22 May 2026.]

Digital Video Ideas for Colleges, Universities, and Professional Schools



Ohio University



Carnegie Mellon Universitiy



Falmouth University



Gulf Coast State College

Trending News

Trending Articles related to Colleges, Universities, and Professional Schools

- Invest In Managers First To Build Workforce Scaffolding, Not Just Skills
  Oct 09, 2026
- License Fix, Named Among the Best Schools for General Contractors in Florida, Launches Pearson VUE-Inspired Student Portal
  Oct 03, 2026
- How K–12 Districts Are Boosting Student Literacy With Technology
  Oct 01, 2026
- Best Apps To Learn Japanese Of 2026
  Oct 01, 2026
- How K–12 Districts Are Boosting Student Literacy With Technology
  Sep 30, 2026
- Best Online Philosophy Degrees Of 2026
  Sep 21, 2026
- 3 Questions for Richard Novak of EduStrategy Group
  Sep 18, 2026
- What the Rise of Big Online Universities Reveals About the Future of Higher Education
  Sep 11, 2026
- Featured Gig: Mich. Assoc. Dir., Learning Innovation Research
  Sep 11, 2026

Source: Google, BuzzSumo November 02, 2026

Know the Customers

Target Customers

Students vary with type of institution, but in most cases, students apply to earn licenses or degrees to further career prospects.

Traditionally, colleges and universities target the young adult population. However, they also extend programs to adult learners through continuing education and online programs.

Overall, the market tends to be:

- Primary traditional undergraduates (high school juniors and seniors planning 2- or 4-year degrees)
- Adult and working learners (over 25 pursuing part-time, online, or return-to-college pathways)
- Graduate and professional degree seekers (master, doctoral, MBA, law, medical, and other professional programs)
- Community college transfer-intent students (2-year students planning to move to 4-year schools)
- Employer partners and corporate education buyers (companies funding degrees, certificates, and custom training)

[Source: “Why Market Segmentation in Higher Education Matters.” insidehighered.com, 2024. Web. 19 May. 2026.]

Target Customers by Mile Radius

Most customers are drawn from a 94 mile radius. The median distance students will travel to college is around 94 miles from their hometown. About 75% of students will travel within 230 miles from home.
[Source: “College Search by City and Distance.” Collegesimply.com, n.d. Web. Feb. 2024.]

Top Factors People Consider When Choosing This Type Of Account

Affordability remains the dominant driver in higher education inquiry behavior, with 66% of learners identifying cost as a primary consideration when researching institutions. Nearly half of prospective students (49%) reported that the availability of desired academic programs influenced their decision to inquire.

Financial support opportunities continue to play a major role in enrollment consideration, with 42% of learners citing scholarships as a key factor. Flexible learning options are also increasingly important, as 35% of learners said preferred program format or modality influenced their inquiry decisions.

- 66% cited affordability as a primary reason for inquiry.
- 49% were influenced by programs offered.
- 42% cited scholarships offered.
- 35% prioritized preferred format or modality.
- 33% valued alignment with institutional values.
- 30% considered institutional reputation important.
- 29% cited ease of finding information.
- 28% valued ease of admission.

Cost continues to be the single largest barrier preventing prospective students from engaging with institutions in the first place. Six in ten learners (60%) reported that tuition and fees were the primary reason they chose not to inquire about a school, reinforcing the growing importance of affordability in the enrollment decision-making process.

Beyond cost, learners also cited concerns related to institutional fit, academic offerings and credit transfer policies. These findings suggest that modern learners are evaluating institutions earlier and more critically, often eliminating schools before direct engagement occurs.

- 60% cited cost of tuition and fees as the primary reason for not inquiring
- 30% reported poor institutional fit
- 21% cited lack of credit acceptance
- 21% believed another institution offered a stronger major

- 21% said the school did not offer their desired major

Additionally, cost remains the leading reason learners choose not to move forward after initially inquiring about an institution, with 56% of prospective students citing affordability concerns as the primary barrier to application. Flexibility-related factors also play a significant role in application abandonment:

- 56% cited cost as the primary reason for not applying
- 28% reported lack of flexibility in program scheduling
- 22% cited concerns about program length
- 20% were unable to use federal financial aid
- 20% said the institution did not offer their preferred modality or format

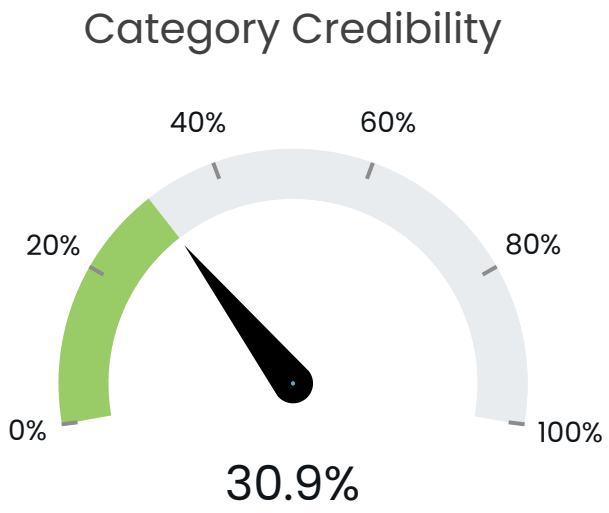
Note that

- 40% of learners considered additional schools after their initial inquiry to a school
- 26% continued exploring other schools after applying
- 28% continued researching other schools after enrolling

[Source: "Modern Learner 2.0." educationdynamics, 2026. Web. 22 May 2026.]

Category Trust+Credibility

> *30.9% of U.S. Adults believe the marketing practices of colleges/universities (including trade schools) are credible*



	Audience	All Respondents	Difference
65+	**24.1%**	21.6%	**+12%**
35-44	19.3%	18.2%	+6%
18-24	9.3%	9.6%	-3%
55-64	17.5%	18.5%	-5%
45-54	14.8%	15.8%	-6%
25-34	15.1%	16.6%	-9%

"More likely" or "less likely" than the average U.S. adult 18+.

Credibility - and whether a person has it or not - determines who you trust for guidance and information you use to make decisions in your everyday life. The four components of credibility for any human being are (1) being known, (2) being likable, (3) being helpful, and (4) being trustworthy. Credibility is gained (or lost) by what one says, how they say it, what they do and, finally, what others say about them. Having credibility also requires having others' best interests at heart.

SOURCE: 2026 State of Credibility 2026 Methodology

Trust Drivers

69.1% of U.S. adults **do not indicate a belief that the marketing** of colleges/universities (including trade schools) is credible. The following responses are from this audience of consumers.

> *What are the best ways for a company to demonstrate their credibility, trustworthiness and value through their marketing practices?*

Marketing Practice	Audience
Being transparent about what their product or service can and cannot do	65.1%
Showing real customers and authentic experiences rather than overly polished or staged advertising	62.9%
Making pricing, fees and terms easy to find without having to dig for them	53.5%
Clearly disclosing when their content is sponsored, paid or AI-generated	46.9%
Responding publicly and personally to negative reviews rather than ignoring them	44.8%
Providing and standing behind a clear, easy-to-use refund or satisfaction guarantee	44.4%
Taking a clear, consistent and authentic stand on values without changing them based on trends	38.7%
Showing the real people behind the business rather than hiding behind a brand	37.1%
Being visibly involved in and giving back to their community	35.3%
Being findable and well-represented across Google, AI search and review platforms	23.8%
Displaying third-party recognition such as industry awards, certifications, accreditations, or media coverage	19.4%
Emailing, calling and/or texting me less often	17.3%

How do you tell if a company you've never heard of before is legitimate?

Vetting Method	Audience
I search for them on Google or another search engine.	55.6%
I look for reviews on sites like Yelp, Trustpilot or Google Reviews.	47.6%
I ask friends, family or colleagues if they've heard of them.	44.6%
I ask myself if the offer seems too good to be true.	39.8%
I check their Better Business Bureau rating or complaints.	38.6%
I check for their professional-looking website with a physical address and phone number.	37.6%
I look for industry certifications, association memberships or if they're licensed in my state.	34.5%
If I have any doubts, I simply move on and look for someone else.	32.5%
I check their social media presence to see how active, responsive and authentic they are.	27%
I search for them on an AI assistant like ChatGPT.	16.1%

SOURCE: 2026 State of Credibility 2026 Methodology

Interests+Attitudes

Additional intelligence for audiences often targeted by colleges, universities, and professional schools from AudienceSCAN®

- Parents of Teenagers
- Students: Full-time
- New Career Skill Seekers
- Generation Z

College Tuition Buyers

Digital Usage: College Tuition Buyers

> *6.5% of U.S. adults said "College tuition for you or a family member (not student loan debt)" when asked: "When it comes to personal, financial or professional services or investments, I expect to pay for the following in the next 12 months....."*

206%
More likely to
Read a Blog Every Day
(69.8% of audience)

22%
More likely to
Research a product or service on a local store website before purchasing
(31.7% of audience)

43%
Less likely to
Go Past First Search Page Results

(26.7% of audience)

I enjoy sharing my experiences with products/stores on social media

Rank		Audience	All U.S.	Difference
1	If I have a GOOD experience with a product or store, I will usually share it with my friends using social media or by posting a positive review	**39.3**	26.4	49.0
2	If I have a BAD experience with a product or store, I will usually share it using social media or by posting a negative review	25.5	16.6	**54.0**

"College Tuition Buyers" are defined by 2026 AudienceSCAN®
"More likely" or "less likely" than the average U.S. adult 18+.
SOURCE: 2026 AudienceSCAN®

B2C Advertising Response: College Tuition Buyers

> *When have you last seen/heard an advertisement of this type that led you to take action?*

Past 30 Days

Rank		Regional Audience	Entire Region	Differen
1	Ad on a social network	**50.7%**	35.9%	+41%
2	Online display ads (banners and pop-up ads)	45.4%	30%	**+51%**
3	Streaming TV advertising (such as Hulu, Pluto TV or YouTube TV)	**48.8%**	36.7%	+33%
4	Ad on search results pages (like on Google, Yahoo or Bing)	**48.2%**	35.8%	+35%
5	Ad that plays before or during the video you want to watch	44.9%	31.1%	+44%
6	Mobile phone app or text message	**47.4%**	36.6%	+30%
7	Television (traditional, including cable or satellite subscription)	**45.8%**	34.7%	+32%
8	Emailed ad or newsletter	41.5%	28.6%	+45%

Past Year

Rank		Regional Audience	Entire Region	Difference
1	Ad on a social network	**80%**	59.2%	+35%
2	Ad on search results pages (like on Google, Yahoo or Bing)	**79%**	59.7%	+32%
3	Online display ads (banners and pop-up ads)	75.4%	53.1%	+42%
4	Ad that plays before or during the video you want to watch	74.8%	53.5%	+40%
5	Streaming TV advertising (such as Hulu, Pluto TV or YouTube TV)	**76.8%**	58.2%	+32%
6	Mobile phone app or text message	**76.5%**	58.1%	+32%
7	Television (traditional, including cable or satellite subscription)	**76.8%**	60%	+28%

Rank		Regional Audience	Entire Region	Differen
9	Text link ad on a website	40%	27.3%	+47%
10	Ads at movie theater	35.2%	21.5%	**+64%**
11	Outdoor ad/sign/billboard/transit	36%	23.6%	**+53%**
12	Ads/Coupons in your mailbox	40.4%	29.9%	+35%
13	Radio (over-the-air, online, mobile or tablet)	37.3%	25.5%	+46%
14	Newspaper (print, online, mobile or tablet)	35.3%	23.5%	**+50%**
15	Magazine (print, online, mobile or on tablet)	32.9%	21.5%	**+53%**
16	Ad on a podcast	33.8%	22.7%	+49%
17	Advertising circulars in your mailbox or inserted in the newspaper	35.7%	27.2%	+31%

Rank		Regional Audience	Entire Region	Difference
8	Radio (over-the-air, online, mobile or tablet)	70.3%	47.6%	**+48%**
9	Emailed ad or newsletter	73%	52.8%	+38%
10	Outdoor ad/sign/billboard/transit	68.9%	46.1%	**+49%**
11	Ads at movie theater	65.9%	42.6%	**+55%**
12	Ads/Coupons in your mailbox	72.6%	56.2%	+29%
13	Text link ad on a website	69.1%	49.5%	+40%
14	Newspaper (print, online, mobile or tablet)	66%	44.7%	**+48%**
15	Magazine (print, online, mobile or on tablet)	65.3%	44%	**+48%**
16	Ad on a podcast	63.5%	42.5%	**+49%**
17	Advertising circulars in your mailbox or inserted in the newspaper	68%	52.2%	+30%

SOURCE: 2026 AudienceSCAN®

* % total may not equal 100% because audience could select more than one answer to this question.

Did You Know

> ***College Tuition Buyers*** *are* ***50% more likely*** *to take action by checking a company's blog to check reviews on the advertiser after seeing an ad.*

> *When* ***College Tuition Buyers*** *search a business online,* ***30.7%*** *usually have a company name in mind.*

> ***College Tuition Buyers*** *are* ***81% more likely*** *to check a company's blog to evaluate their expertise and subject knowledge than the average U.S. adult.*

> ***College Tuition Buyers*** *in the U.S. are* ***134%*** *more likely to participate in* ***playing esports*** *than the average adult.*

SOURCE: 2026 AudienceSCAN®

Know the Competition

Top Major Accounts and Franchises

Colleges, Universities, and Professional Schools

Strategic Education, Inc.

Local Competitors

Colleges, Universities, and Professional Schools

Other similar or related local account types to colleges, universities, and professional schools in your market.

- Technical and Trade Schools
- Colleges, Community
- Colleges, For Profit
- Personal and Professional Coaches

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